

NUMBERS OVER NOISE

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T20 World Cups have a habit of being decided before reputations can catch up. In conditions as specific as India and Sri Lanka, roles matter more than stardom, and small patterns often explain big moments.

This package looks at 11 players we believe could shape the tournament, broken down by role across the team sheet. Using numbers rather than noise, each profile digs into how they score, where they take wickets, and why their games may be particularly suited to these conditions.

It is not a ranking or a prediction. Just a sharper look at players through the lens of data and context, and what that might mean once the margins begin to shrink.

The data includes all T20s since the start of 2023, the year when the Impact Player rule was introduced in the Indian Premier League (IPL), which significantly changed the landscape of the format, sending run rates into the stratosphere and bowlers into hiding.

With the large part of the T20 World Cup to be staged in India, one can expect more high-scoring matches that heighten the mismatch between bat and ball, and where only the bowlers who can best adapt to adversity eventually survive. Similarly, though modern-day T20

cricket is a batter's haven, the willow-wielders are expected to get going from ball one, without the slightest thought to wicket preservation. Against such a backdrop, only the truly liberated thrive with the bat, while those with the ball are tasked with outwitting that sense of freedom at the other end of the 22 yards.

Legend:

RAP — Right-arm pace; **LAP** — Left-arm pace; **SLAO** — Slow left-arm orthodox; **LWS** — Left-arm wrist spin; **OS** — Off spin; **LB** — Leg break; **Inf** — Infinity. (All data since January 2023)